WEEK 7 · LECTURE L2 · UNIT III

Engagement Strategy Frameworks

Three horizons, deliberate and emergent strategy, the strength of an HR system, and why employees attribute motives to HR.

R K Singh · Senior Professor, Department of Commerce · Delhi School of Economics, University of Delhi

DSEH004 · Performance Management and Employee Engagement · M.Com. PGCF 2025 · Exam preparation edition

AFTER THIS LECTURE YOU SHOULD BE ABLE TO

What this lecture prepares you for

- Apply three horizon planning to an engagement strategy.
- Distinguish deliberate from emergent strategy.
- Explain the features of a strong HR system.
- Explain how employee attributions shape the effect of HR practices.

COURSE OUTCOMES

CLO 2 (apply engagement strategies) and CLO 4 (design evidence based interventions).

COMMIT BEFORE THEORY

An engagement strategy is a list of engagement programs.

Agree or disagree. What makes a set of programs a strategy?

THREE HORIZONS · BAGHAI, COLEY AND WHITE (1999), APPLIED

Planning engagement across time

Horizon	In growth strategy	In an engagement strategy
H1	Defend and extend the core	Fix the conditions people meet every day
H2	Build emerging businesses	Build manager capability and new practices
H3	Create options for the future	Experiment with new ways of working

EXAM LENS

The application to engagement is course framing; the three horizons come from growth strategy.

THEORY IN DEPTH · MINTZBERG AND WATERS (1985)

Deliberate and emergent strategy

THE CORE IDEA

Some intended strategy is never realized, and some realized strategy was never intended.

HOW IT WORKS

Realized strategy is the pattern in actual decisions, combining deliberate plans with emergent responses.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

A typology, so it describes strategy more than it tells managers what to do.

IN PRACTICE

A firm intends a culture of feedback; what employees experience is the pattern of who gets promoted.

EXAM LENS

Judge an engagement strategy by the pattern of decisions employees experience, not the plan on paper.

THEORY IN DEPTH · BOWEN AND OSTROFF (2004)

A strong HR system

THE CORE IDEA

HR practices affect performance through the shared climate they create, and only a strong system creates one.

HOW IT WORKS

Strength needs distinctiveness (visible, understandable, legitimate), consistency over time, and consensus among decision makers.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

A conceptual model; strength is hard to measure directly.

IN PRACTICE

In a weak system each manager sends a different message, so employees read the manager, not the policy.

EXAM LENS

Use it to explain why good practices fail when managers apply them unevenly.

THEORY IN DEPTH · NISHII, LEPAK AND SCHNEIDER (2008)

Why employees think HR does it

THE CORE IDEA

Employees attribute motives to HR practices, and the attribution changes the effect.

HOW IT WORKS

Practices seen as aimed at quality and wellbeing related to positive attitudes; those seen as aimed at cost or control did not.

LIMITS AND CRITIQUE

Attributions are hard to change once formed.

IN PRACTICE

The same pulse survey can be read as care or as surveillance, depending on what follows it.

EXAM LENS

Pair it with Bowen and Ostroff: a strong, consistent system makes the intended attribution more likely.

COMPARE AND EVALUATE

Three lenses on engagement strategy

Lens	Key question	Main risk
Three horizons	Are we balancing now and later?	Neglecting H1 basics
Emergent strategy	What pattern do employees see?	Plans that never become practice
HR system strength	Is the message consistent?	Managers send mixed signals

PRACTICE FOR THE END TERM EXAMINATION

Questions to rehearse

"Good HR practices fail because of weak HR systems." Discuss using Bowen and Ostroff and Nishii et al. **20 marks**

A strong answer: explains system strength and attributions; shows how managers send signals; proposes ways to strengthen the system.

Design an 18 month engagement strategy for an Indian company using three horizon planning. **20 marks**

A strong answer: sets actions for each horizon; links to drivers; addresses governance and consistency; notes risks.

Distinguish deliberate from emergent strategy. **10 marks**

A strong answer: definitions; one example each; why it matters for engagement.

CARRY THESE INTO THE EXAMINATION

Three things to remember

1. Strategy is the pattern employees experience, not the plan
2. A strong HR system is distinctive, consistent and agreed
3. Employees' attributions decide whether a practice helps

SET READINGS · FROM THE LESSON PLAN

Read for this lecture

Saks, A. M. (2006). Antecedents and consequences of employee engagement. *Journal of Managerial Psychology, 21*(7), 600–619.

Macey, W. H., Schneider, B., Barbera, K. M., & Young, S. A. (2009). *Employee engagement: Tools for analysis, practice, and competitive advantage*. Wiley Blackwell. Chapters 1 to 2.

People Matters and SHRM India: a selected case on an Indian engagement transformation (Wipro, Infosys or HCLTech), as listed in the Lesson Plan.

HOW TO USE THESE

These are the Week 7 set readings. Macey et al. (2009) is the core reading for this lecture.

THEORY SOURCES · FOR REFERENCE

Sources for this lecture (1 of 1)

Works named on the slides of this lecture. They are background sources, not set readings.

Baghai, M., Coley, S., & White, D. (1999). *The alchemy of growth*. Perseus Books.

Bowen, D. E., & Ostroff, C. (2004). Understanding HRM firm performance linkages: The role of the "strength" of the HRM system. *Academy of Management Review, 29*(2), 203–221. https://doi.org/10.5465/amr.2004.12736076

Mintzberg, H., & Waters, J. A. (1985). Of strategies, deliberate and emergent. *Strategic Management Journal, 6*(3), 257–272. https://doi.org/10.1002/smj.4250060306

Nishii, L. H., Lepak, D. P., & Schneider, B. (2008). Employee attributions of the “why” of HR practices: Their effects on employee attitudes and behaviors, and customer satisfaction. *Personnel Psychology, 61*(3), 503–545. https://doi.org/10.1111/j.1744-6570.2008.00121.x